Fresh Strategy



BUILDING WITH BETTER FEEDBACK

How AI-augmented expert panels and user feedback help teams validate new ideas faster

Stéphanie Kioutsoukis · AI for Good Innovation Factory 2026 · Masterclass · Tue 7 July 2026, 10:15

WHY INNOVATION FAILS

MOST NEW PRODUCTS FAIL.

30,000 new consumer products launch every year, "and many of them fail." HBS Working Knowledge, 2011

» They are built around the product, not around the customer's need.

Clayton Christensen, Harvard Business School, 2011

43%

of failed startups had poor product-market fit

CB Insights, 2026 · 385 VC-backed shutdowns since 2023

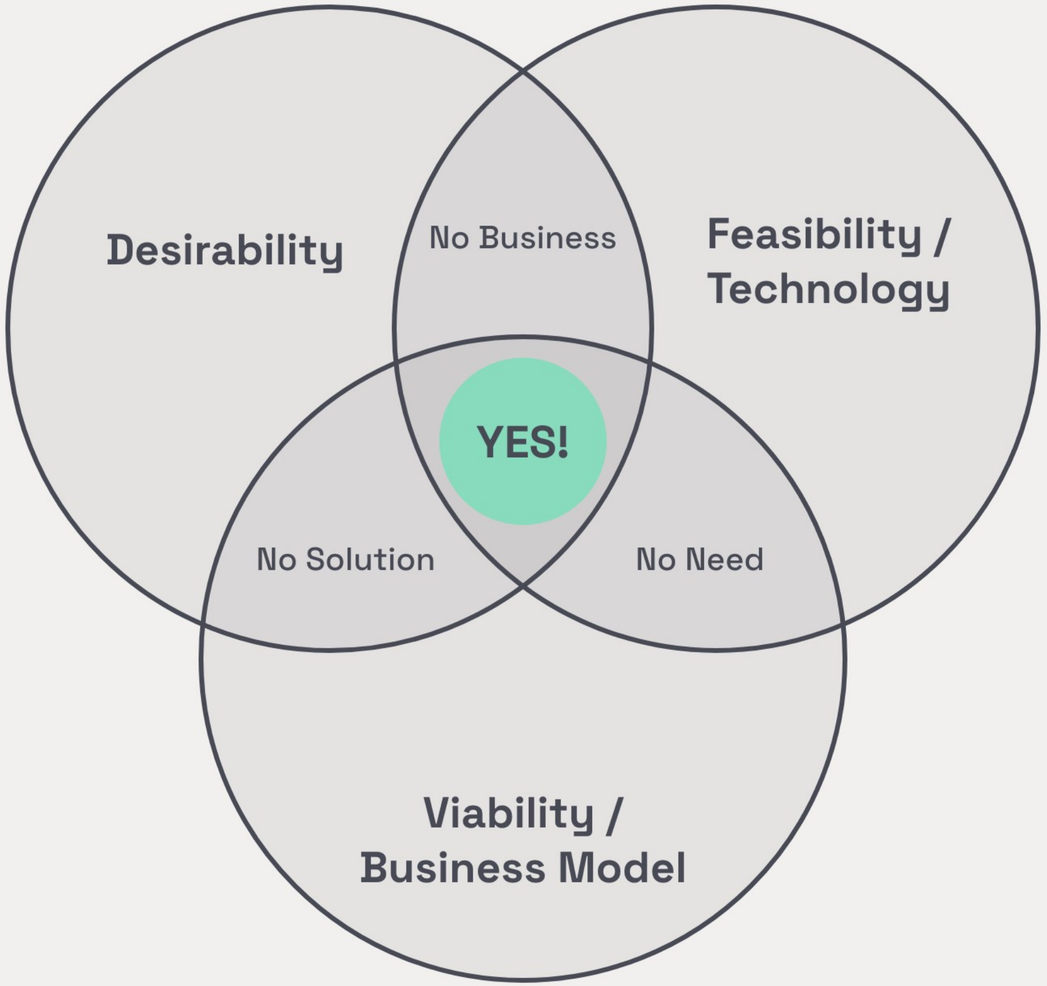
10-20%

of tested ideas actually work. Even experts misjudge which ones.

Kohavi & Thomke, Harvard Business Review, 2017 · experiments at Google and Bing

Sources: HBS Working Knowledge, Clay Christensen's Milkshake Marketing, 2011 · CB Insights, Top reasons startups fail, 2026 · HBR, The surprising power of online experiments, 2017

SUSTAINABILITY REQUIRES REVENUE



- Which problem do we solve for whom?
- How do we earn money?
- How do we solve it?

DEEP TECH VALIDATION TRAP

EXPERT PROOF

IS THIS TECHNICALLY FEASIBLE?

- Clinical/scientific credibility
- Regulatory pathway
- Prototype quality
- Patent / IP
- ...

MARKET PROOF

WILL THIS BE ADOPTED?

- User pain
- Clear buyer vs budget owner
- Procurement path
- Adoption behaviour
- ...



Most teams over-invest in proving it can work, and under-invest in proving it will be bought and used.

WE DON'T KNOW WHAT WE DON'T KNOW.

THE FEEDBACK BOTTLENECK

NEEDS FEEDBACK FROM

Experts, Users, Buyers, Regulators, Investors

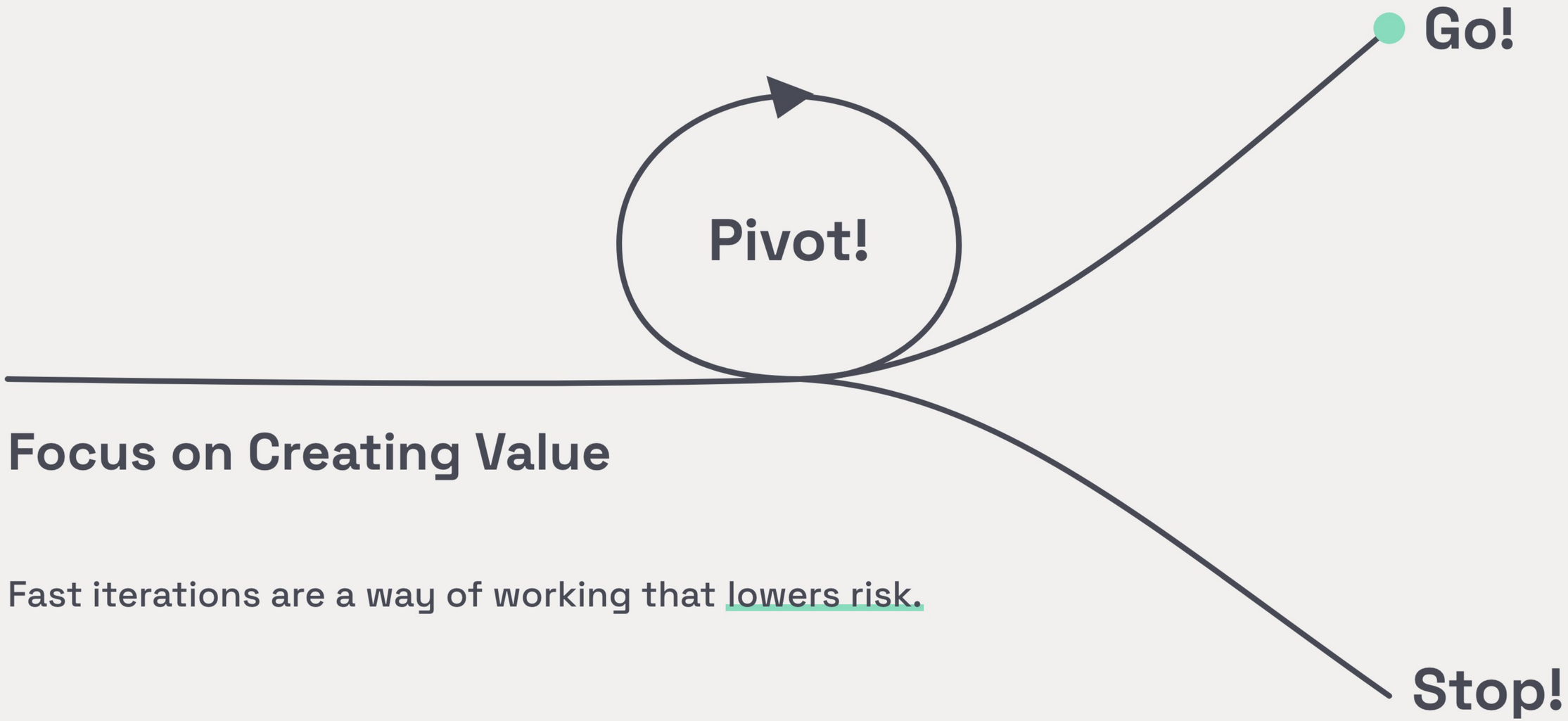
BUT ACCESS IS LIMITED

- Hard to reach
- Slow to schedule
- Expensive
- Biased samples
- Too late

The risk: you build on guesses, because real feedback arrives too late.



ITERATIVE WORK AND FAST VALIDATION



Focus on Creating Value

Fast iterations are a way of working that lowers risk.

WHAT ARE SYNTHETIC PERSONAS?



Synthetic personas are AI-created versions of the people you want feedback from or understand.

They are built to respond like a target user, buyer, or stakeholder might respond, based on the data and context you give them.

They help you quickly explore different reactions, objections, and scenarios before doing slower real-world research.

WHY NOW

Until recently, the only way to hear a buyer's objections was to find the buyer. AI can now play that role from your own context and data in minutes, so you can run the first feedback rounds before you book a single interview.

TYPES OF SYNTHETIC PERSONAS

EXPERT PERSONA

AI plays an expert role.

EXAMPLES	Clinician · Regulator · UX expert · Investor · Data/privacy expert · Growth advisor
BEST FOR	Stress-testing logic, safety, feasibility, pitch, risks, and quality.
RISK	Can sound authoritative even when missing context.

CUSTOMER PERSONA

AI pretends to be a target customer.

EXAMPLES	Patient · Nurse · NGO programme officer · Procurement lead
BEST FOR	Surfacing pains, objections, workflow issues, trust barriers, and adoption questions.
RISK	Weak for predicting real behaviour, price, demand, or willingness to pay.

WHAT THE ADVICE IS GROUNDED IN

1 · Generic prompt-based

You only describe the role: "Act as a hospital buyer."

2 · Context-rich

You give your product, market, pitch, assumptions, and target user.

3 · Data-grounded

You give real interviews, survey answers, CRM notes, pilot feedback, or support tickets.

WHERE SYNTHETIC RESEARCH FITS YOUR WORKFLOW

Early exploration & problem discovery

Map the problem before you commit time and money. Use synthetic personas to surface likely user pains, behaviours, objections, and context so your first real interviews start with better questions.

Concept & messaging testing

Test different versions of your idea before you pitch or build. Use synthetic personas to compare product concepts, value propositions, and messaging angles across different users, buyers, and stakeholders.

Insight between real feedback rounds

Keep learning when real research is too slow, expensive, or hard to schedule. Use synthetic personas between customer calls, expert reviews, pilots, and investor meetings to spot gaps and prepare the next conversation.

DISCLAIMER Synthetic personas are a discovery co-pilot, not a replacement for real customer research. Use them to explore the problem, sharpen your questions, and focus your limited time with real users, buyers, experts, and investors.

IS FAKE RESEARCH BETTER THAN NO RESEARCH?

WHAT RESEARCH SUGGESTS	WHAT IT MEANS FOR FOUNDERS
Human-AI hybrid beats human-only and LLM-only in one 2025 marketing study	Use AI to prepare research, then validate with humans
Only 24.9% of 285 LLM-human comparisons were similar; 65.3% diverged	Default assumption: synthetic feedback may be wrong
Synthetic respondents overstated willingness-to-pay for indulgent products in one 2026 pricing study	Never use synthetic personas to set price or prove demand.

Sources: Arora, Chakraborty & Nishimura, AI-Human Hybrids for Marketing Research, Journal of Marketing 89(2), 2025 · Sarstedt, Adler, Rau & Schmitt, Your Next Respondent Might Be an LLM, NIM Marketing Intelligence Review 18(1), 2026 · Oetzel & Maiberger, How price sensitive is AI?, Journal of Marketing Analytics, 2026

AI CREATES HYPOTHESES. HUMANS CREATE EVIDENCE.

AI OUTPUT	HYPOTHESES TO TEST	HUMAN VALIDATION
"Procurement may be complex."	Procurement is a major adoption barrier.	**Interview hospital buyers / procurement leads.**
"Nurses may not want another dashboard."	Workflow burden will reduce adoption.	**Interview nurses / observe workflow.**
"The buyer may not own the budget."	Budget ownership is unclear.	**Interview budget holders.**
"Users may distrust AI recommendations."	Trust is a key adoption condition.	**Interview users / test prototype explanation.**
"Investors may question route to market."	GTM story is not credible enough.	**Ask advisors / investors for pitch feedback.**

WHAT MAKES A SYNTHETIC PERSONA RELIABLE?

HIGH

Human-calibrated persona
Top outputs checked with real people
Prompt + model version logged
Updated with new interviews
Used as hypothesis, not evidence

NEAR-ZERO

Generic prompt only
"Act as a customer"
No real context
No real data



MEDIUM

Real data grounding
5+ real interviews
Survey verbatims
CRM / waitlist data
Reviews, forums, support tickets
Direct customer quotes

LOW

Project context added
Pitch deck
Product description
Target segment
Founder assumptions

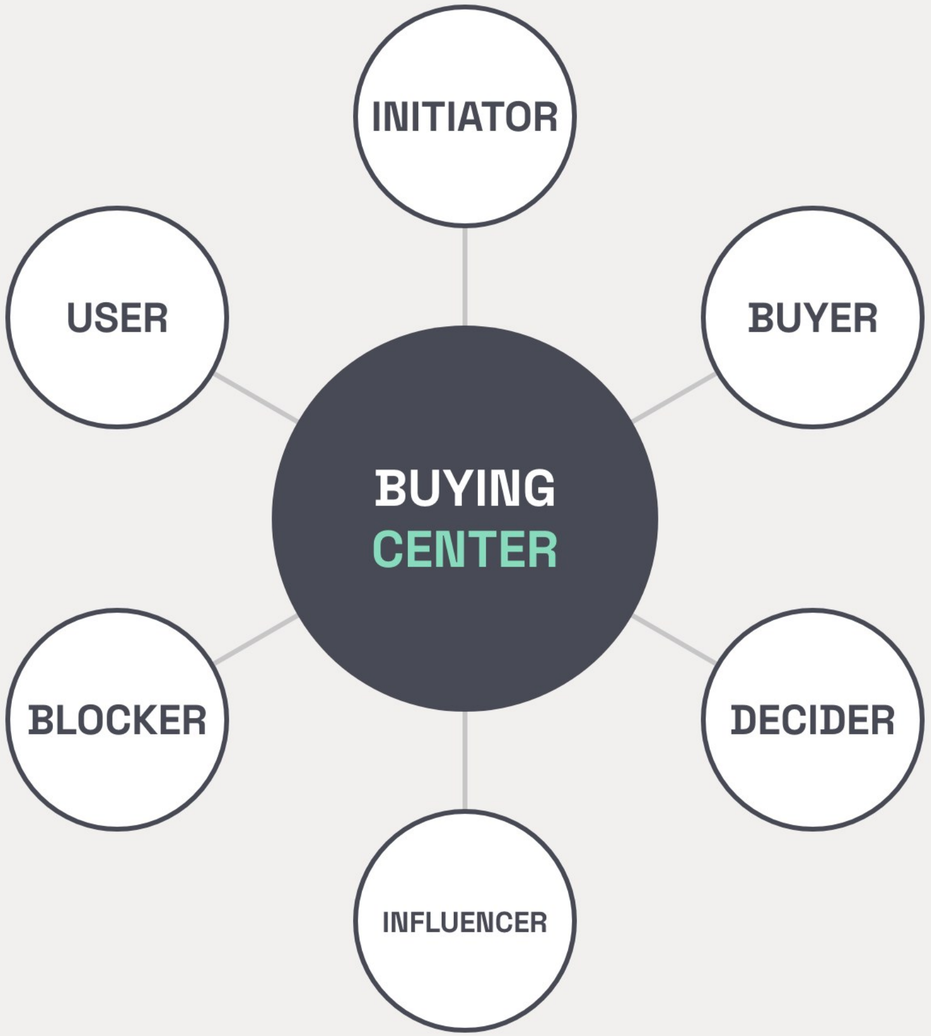
LOW-MEDIUM

Specific persona conditioning · Role · geography · demographics
Current behaviour · Pain point · Decision criteria · "What this persona would not say"

SETTING UP AN EXPERT PANEL

1	What are we trying to improve?	Examples: pitch, product concept, clinical logic, GTM, regulatory pathway, data model.
2	Whose expertise do we need?	Examples: clinician, regulator, buyer, investor, UX expert, data/privacy expert.
3	What does the expert need to know?	Examples: Product, target user, market, current evidence, assumptions, constraints.
4	What should the expert look for?	Examples: Weaknesses, missing evidence, risks, objections, adoption blockers, unclear logic.
5	What should we get back?	Examples: Top risks, questions to test, evidence needed, next human conversations.

SIMULATE THE ADOPTION SYSTEM



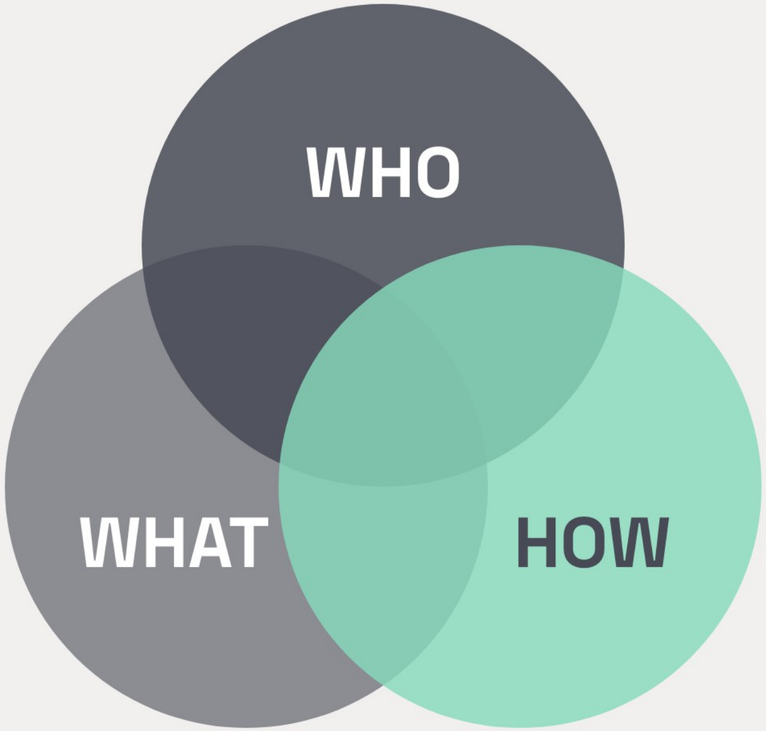
THE MAGIC FORMULA

Who are we trying to understand?

- Segment
- Role
- Context
- Decision power
- Motivations
- Barriers

What problem are they dealing with?

- Needs
- Pains
- Current workaround
- Frustrations
- Desired outcome
- What they already use
- Reference points



How do they decide or adopt?

- Buying journey
- Path to use
- Approval process
- Friction points
- Trust barriers
- Switching costs
- Reasons to stay

ASK BETTER QUESTIONS

DO NOT ASK FOR APPROVAL! ASK FOR FRICTION.

- What would make this fail?
- What would make you not use this?
- What would make this hard to adopt?
- What would this need to replace?
- Who else would need to approve this?
- What would make you distrust it?
- What evidence would you need before trying it?
- What would stop this from becoming a priority?
- Which part of the pitch feels weakest?
- What would this compete with in your workflow or budget?

ASK BETTER QUESTIONS

ASK FOR WORDS, NOT SCORES.

Free-text reactions and A-vs-B ranking - never a rating or a price.

DON'T

~~*"On a scale of 1-10, how likely are you to buy this? What would you pay?"*~~

DO

"You are a procurement lead at a mid-size hospital in Kenya. React in your own words: first thought, biggest hesitation, what you'd use instead. Then: here are two versions, A and B - which do you prefer, and why?"

WHERE SYNTHETIC PERSONAS BREAK

Synthetic personas are (still) weak in predicting real customer behaviour, such as:

- What price people will pay
- Whether customers will buy
- How large the market is
- Whether users will adopt
- Whether investors will invest
- Whether to launch, pivot, or stop
- Non-Western / non-English markets - model fidelity drops sharply.

They break for one reason: a persona has no hidden interior - only what people say in public, not what they privately think or do.

TURN SYNTHETIC FEEDBACK INTO A REAL TEST

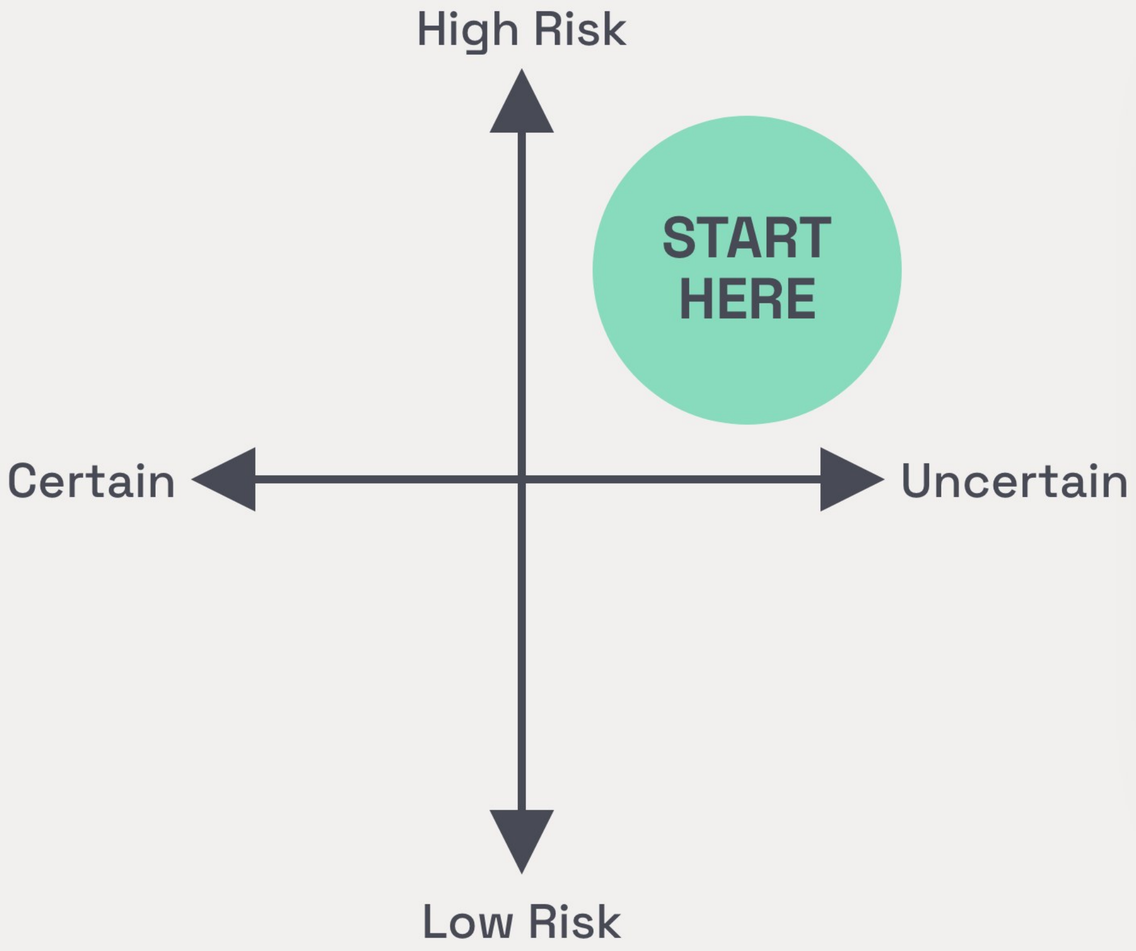
We believe that... [synthetic persona hypothesis]	[Customer X] will make [desired behaviour change] if we do/say [planned activity]
To verify we will... [real-world validation step]	[talk to customer X] [get letters of intent] [do an A/B campaign on LinkedIn]
We need to measure... [signal or evidence]	[% of people buying] [% of shares on social media]
We are right if... [clear success threshold]	[>10% conversions] [>30% of returning customers]

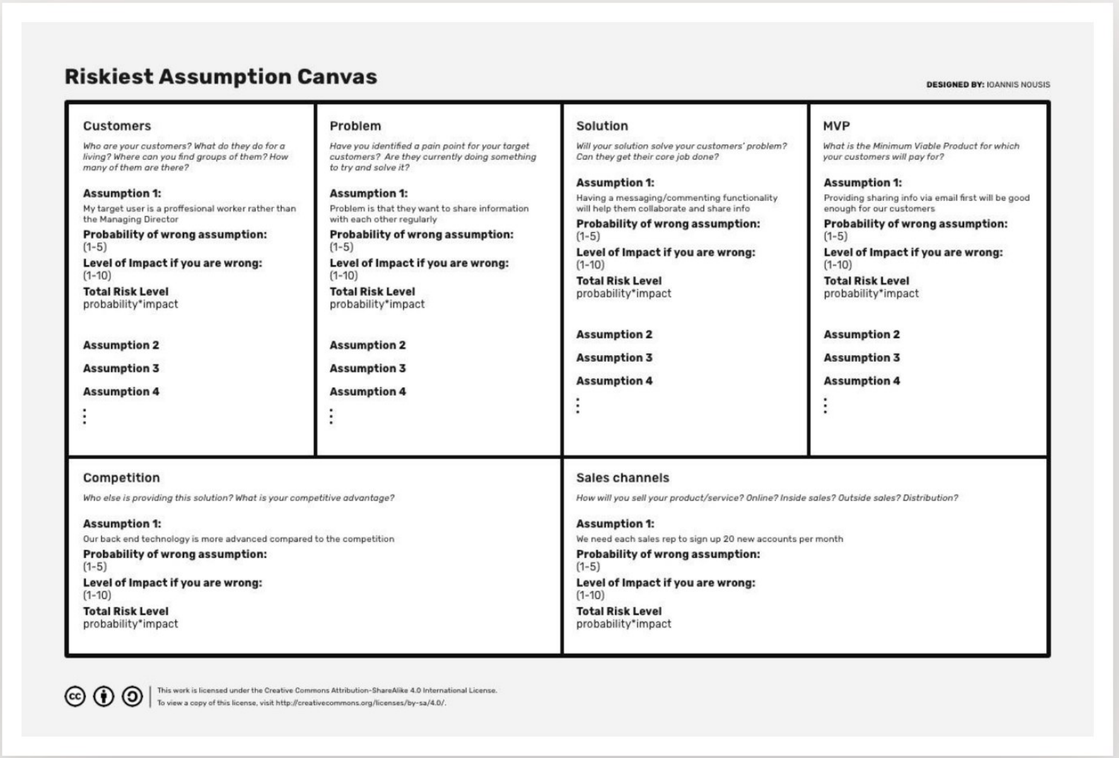
EXAMPLE

TURN SYNTHETIC FEEDBACK INTO A REAL TEST

We believe that... [synthetic persona hypothesis]	Hospital buyers may see procurement complexity as a major adoption barrier.
To verify we will... [real-world validation step]	Interview 5 hospital buyers and map the approval path.
We need to measure... [signal or evidence]	Who approves, which budget pays, expected timeline, key objections.
We are right if... [clear success threshold]	**At least 3 of 5 buyers can identify a realistic procurement path and budget owner.**

START WITH THE RISKIEST ASSUMPTION





Riskiest Assumption Canvas

DESIGNED BY: IOANNIS NOUSIS

Customers	Problem	Solution	MVP
Who are your customers? What do they do for a living? Where can you find groups of them? How many of them are there?	*Have you identified a pain point for your target customers? Are they currently doing something to try and solve it?*	*Will your solution solve your customers' problem? Can they get their core job done?*	*What is the Minimum Viable Product for which your customers will pay for?*
Assumption 1: My target user is a proffesional worker rather than the Managing Director **Probability of wrong assumption:** (1-5) **Level of Impact if you are wrong:** (1-10) **Total Risk Level** probability*impact	**Assumption 1:** Problem is that they want to share information with each other regularly **Probability of wrong assumption:** (1-5) **Level of Impact if you are wrong:** (1-10) **Total Risk Level** probability*impact	**Assumption 1:** Having a messaging/commenting functionality will help them collaborate and share info **Probability of wrong assumption:** (1-5) **Level of Impact if you are wrong:** (1-10) **Total Risk Level** probability*impact	**Assumption 1:** Providing sharing info via email first will be good enough for our customers **Probability of wrong assumption:** (1-5) **Level of Impact if you are wrong:** (1-10) **Total Risk Level** probability*impact
Assumption 2 **Assumption 3** **Assumption 4** ⋮	**Assumption 2** **Assumption 3** **Assumption 4** ⋮	**Assumption 2** **Assumption 3** **Assumption 4** ⋮	**Assumption 2** **Assumption 3** **Assumption 4** ⋮

Competition	Sales channels
Who else is providing this solution? What is your competitive advantage?	*How will you sell your product/service? Online? Inside sales? Outside sales? Distribution?*
Assumption 1: Our back end technology is more advanced compared to the competition **Probability of wrong assumption:** (1-5) **Level of Impact if you are wrong:** (1-10) **Total Risk Level** probability*impact	**Assumption 1:** We need each sales rep to sign up 20 new accounts per month **Probability of wrong assumption:** (1-5) **Level of Impact if you are wrong:** (1-10) **Total Risk Level** probability*impact

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Source: Riskiest Assumption Canvas, Ioannis Nousis, uxdesign.cc · CC BY-SA 4.0

SETTING UP A VALIDATION LAB AS A PROJECT

CREATE A PROJECT
in ChatGPT or Claude

ADD PROJECT INSTRUCTIONS

CREATE PERSONA CARDS

UPLOAD

- Pitch deck
- Business model
- Target users
- Assumptions
- Interviews
- Pilot feedback

ADD RULES

- Hypotheses, not evidence
- Ask for friction
- Separate expert/ user/ buyer feedback

EXAMPLES

- Synthetic clinician
- Synthetic buyer
- Synthetic regulator
- Synthetic investor
- Synthetic end user…

FRESH MODEL: FROM CHAT TO AUTOMATED SYSTEM

	GENERAL CHAT	PROJECT	PROMPT ENGINEERING	AGENT / APP
Knows general knowledge	✓	✓	✓	✓
Knows my documents	✗	✓	✓	✓
Has a specialist role	✗	Limited	✓	✓
Chooses what knowledge to load	✗	✗	✗	✓
Chooses which tools to use	✗	✗	Limited	✓
Adapts to each request	✗	✗	Limited	✓

FRESH MODEL: FROM CHAT TO AUTOMATED SYSTEM

AREA	DESCRIPTION	EXAMPLE	WHEN
AI Helper	Use GPT/Claude in chat to act as one synthetic expert, user, buyer, or blocker	*Act as a hospital procurement lead. What would make you reject this pilot?*	One-off checks, daily use, fast feedback
AI Playbook	Use a repeated method with saved prompts, Projects, or Custom GPTs	*Run our pitch through the expert panel: clinician, buyer, regulator, investor, data/privacy expert.*	Repeated project reviews, accelerator sessions, founder workflows
AI Automation Agent	Automate a specific persona task	*Upload a pitch deck and generate: 5 synthetic personas, key objections, hypotheses, and real interview questions.*	When the task is structured and repeated
AI Augmentation Agent	Add synthetic persona insight into an ongoing validation process	*After each real interview, update the persona assumptions and flag what still needs validation.*	When humans need to stay in control but want faster synthesis
AI Agent Team	Multiple AI agents simulate different perspectives and challenge each other	*User agent, buyer agent, blocker agent, regulator agent, and investor agent review the same product and produce a joint risk map.*	When decisions need several perspectives
AI Apps	Build a dedicated tool for persona-based validation	*A validation app that turns a pitch deck into synthetic panels, testable hypotheses, interview guides, and evidence tracking.*	When the workflow is valuable enough to productise

USE SYNTHETIC PERSONAS ACROSS THE INNOVATION LIFECYCLE

EARLY STAGE

EXPLORE

PRODUCT STAGE

STRESS-TEST

GTM STAGE

SHARPEN

SCALING STAGE

DE-RISK

USE CASES ACROSS THE INNOVATION LIFECYCLE

STAGE	BEST USE OF SYNTHETIC PERSONAS	WHAT TO VALIDATE WITH HUMANS
Idea / discovery	Surface pains, assumptions, objections, stakeholder perspectives	Real problem, urgency, current workaround
Product development	Stress-test features, UX, workflow fit, clinical / technical logic	Usability, workflow integration, adoption barriers
MVP / pilot	Prepare pilot questions, anticipate blockers, compare use cases	Real usage, behaviour, pilot outcomes
Marketing & messaging	Compare value propositions, headlines, objections, segment language	Message resonance with real buyers / users
Sales & GTM	Simulate buyer, blocker, procurement, budget owner, channel partner	Buying process, budget, procurement path, sales cycle
Scaling	Stress-test segments, channels, partnerships, operational risks	Unit economics, retention, expansion, local market evidence

TAKEAWAYS

- SYNTHETIC PERSONAS ARE A FAST FIRST PASS, NOT CUSTOMER PROOF.
- THE DATA UNDERNEATH DETERMINES QUALITY.
- ASK FOR FRICTION, NOT APPROVAL.
- CAREFUL WHEN USING SYNTHETIC PERSONAS FOR PRICING, WTP OR MARKET PROOF.
- AI CREATES HYPOTHESES. HUMANS CREATE EVIDENCE.

STAY IN TOUCH.

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Resources

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